



MODULE 02

Feeding Drive

Bonded Foundations



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Welcome

This module is about something every dog does, every single day – eating.

But feeding drive is so much more than hunger. It is about trust, focus, and communication. It is one of the most powerful tools you have to build a relationship with your dog – and most people never realize it.

In the lessons ahead, you will learn how to use the feeding drive to build focus, self-control, and a shared language between you and your dog, all through five games that are a “must know” for every dog owner.

Take your time. Practice with patience. And remember – every meal is an opportunity to connect.

With love,

Roni



LESSON 01

Every Dog Needs to Eat

Understanding feeding drive as a foundation for trust, focus, and communication
– and learning to read your dog through their relationship with food.

Every Dog Needs to Eat

Every dog eats. Every single day. But most people never think about what feeding really means – beyond filling a bowl.

Feeding drive is not just hunger. It is one of the most powerful tools you have to build trust, focus, and communication with your dog. When you understand how to use food intentionally, you unlock a language your dog already speaks.

Food can change your dog's emotional state. This is classical conditioning at its simplest – pairing food with experiences to build positive associations. A dog who eats in a new environment begins to feel safe there. A dog who receives food from your hand begins to trust your hand.

This is not bribery. This is biology. And when we use it with intention, it becomes the foundation of everything we build together.

Reading Your Dog Through Food

When Your Dog Won't Eat

When a dog refuses food, most people think the dog is stubborn or not hungry. But a dog who will not eat is telling you something important.

They might be:

- Overwhelmed by the environment
- Feeling unsafe or stressed
- Finding the task too difficult
- In physical discomfort
- Shutting down emotionally

Refusing food is feedback, not defiance. It is your dog's way of saying: "I cannot learn right now." Listen to that.

How You Deliver Matters

It is not just what you feed – it is how you feed. The speed, the placement, the timing, and the energy behind every piece of food communicates something to your dog.

A treat tossed away says "go explore."

A treat delivered to the mouth says "stay close."

A treat placed on the ground says "settle."

A treat held high says "look up at me."

A loose hand means "don't worry, we're a team" while a tight hand tells your dog to be more careful.

Every delivery is a message. When you become intentional about how you feed, you become a clearer communicator.

The goal is not a dog who works for treats. The goal is a dog who wants to work with you because being with you is where good things happen.



From Feeding to Connection

When we feed with intention, something shifts. The dog stops seeing food as a transaction and starts seeing you as a source of safety and joy.

This is the real power of feeding drive... not the food itself, but what it builds between you. Trust. Attention. Willingness. A dog who checks in with you because they want to, not because they have to.

Every meal, every treat, every piece of food you offer is an opportunity to strengthen your bond. Use it wisely.



The goal is not a dog who works for treats. The goal is a dog who wants to work with you – because being with you is where good things happen.

– Every Dog Needs to Eat

LESSON 02

The Engagement Games

Five games designed to strengthen engagement and communication between you and your dog through food-based play.



01

GAME 01

Ping Pong

Teaching your dog that turning back to you is always the best choice.

GAME 01

Ping Pong

Why do we play this game?

Ping Pong teaches your dog to choose you. Not because they have to – but because coming back to you is always worth it.

The idea is simple: you toss a treat away from you, and when your dog finishes eating it, they turn back toward you. That moment – the turn – is where the magic happens. It is the moment your dog decides that you are more interesting than the environment.

Over time, this game builds a pattern: go out, come back, get rewarded. The dog learns that returning to you is never a dead end. It always leads to something good.

This is the foundation of recall, of focus, and of voluntary engagement.

Ping Pong — How to Play

How to play

Start by positioning yourself next to your dog, holding treats in both hands.

When your dog looks at you, use a marker that says “Chase a Treat” and toss a treat to one side, in a line your dog can track. Once they find the treat and look back toward you, use your Keep Going marker followed by the Chase marker, and toss to the other side.

This creates the back-and-forth flow that gives the game its name.

When your dog understands the game well and is turning back to you immediately after each chase, start raising from the ground until you reach a full standing position, and begin adding motion to the game without confusing your dog.

Once the chasing game feels easy and natural, move to the next level: wait for static eye contact, praise with your Keep Going marker, and only then toss the next treat. When your dog can stay in control in a neutral environment, start adding distractions. Begin with distractions you can control, from a distance your dog can handle, and slowly get closer. Gradually introduce moving distractions.

As your dog becomes more confident, keep adding new environments and more challenging distractions to your training – until your dog can play this game no matter the environment.

A few things to keep in mind:

Some dogs will take a moment to sniff the ground after eating the treat. With these dogs, use your Keep Going marker with excitement as soon as they finish eating, before they drop their nose. This can help them learn the pattern of coming back up and returning to you rather than lingering on the ground.

When you’re just starting out with this game, feel free to reward only through treat tossing. But as you progress, start working on the static reward. Your dog chases a treat, you use your Keep Going marker as they turn back to you, and then wait for them to stop in front of you with eye contact. That moment of eye contact is the behaviour to confirm with your Static Confirmation marker, followed by a Chase.

For some dogs, stopping and staying with you before the chase may become a challenge if they are not mentally ready for it yet. Read your dog and choose the style that fits where they are right now.



Building the Pattern

At first, your dog may take a long time to turn back. That is okay. Patience is part of the process.

What you are building is a habit, a default behavior that says: “when in doubt, check in with my person.”

As the pattern strengthens, you will notice your dog turning faster, with more energy, with more joy. They are not just coming back for the treat. They are coming back because the game is fun and you are the source of it.

This is engagement. Not obedience. Not compliance. A genuine desire to be with you.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The Power of the Turn

In Ping Pong, at first we do not reward the dog for coming to us. We reward the decision to turn back.

That moment. The turn. Is your dog saying:
“I choose you.”

Reinforce that choice, and it will become a habit.

02

GAME 02

Reinforce & Release

Building duration, focus, and voluntary engagement through calm, intentional feeding.

Reinforce & Release

Why do we play this game?

The Reinforce & Release game is one of the most valuable exercises for any dog. It teaches a dog that staying close is always their choice, and that coming back is always worth it. The concept is simple: the dog is rewarded while remaining in contact, and then released with a clear signal. Through this pattern, the dog learns that holding focus leads to good things, and that every exercise has a clear beginning and end.

This game builds duration, focus, and voluntary engagement without any pressure. The dog is never forced to stay; they choose to stay because the pattern makes sense and the outcome is consistently positive. It also strengthens a key part of the communication system: a reliable “keep going” marker that tells the dog they’re on the right track, along with a self-initiated check-in and a default position that becomes second nature over time.

Playing this game at the start of every session offers another benefit: it reveals, almost instantly, how easy or difficult a given environment is for the dog that day, making it one of the best ways to read a dog’s state before moving on to other training. Over time, dogs who play this game regularly settle into focus more quickly, hold position with greater confidence, and wait for the release with calm anticipation rather than anxiety, building an engagement that travels easily into new and more challenging environments.

Reinforce & Release

How to play

Wait for your dog to offer you even the smallest signal of attention, a glance, a step toward you, anything. The moment they do, use your Keep Going marker and deliver a treat from your hand.

Once they've eaten that treat, take one step back. Use your Keep Going marker again to signal that eating the treat was the right move, and place a second treat in your hand. When they eat the second treat, take another step back, use your Keep Going marker, and offer a third treat.

After the third treat, use your Release marker and toss a treat behind you. Let your dog chase it.

The moment they raise their head from the ground and start searching for you, mark with your Keep Going marker, and start the whole sequence again.

This back-and-forth of focus, treat, following your movement, and focus again, often ending in a release, is what keeps this game fun and engaging for your dog. It feels easy to them, basically getting treats for eating treats and then being released, and because it's so much fun to play, they learn to wait for the release before disengaging.

Once your dog understands the pattern well and is checking back in with you quickly after each release, start playing in busier, more distracting environments. As your dog becomes more confident, keep raising the challenge until they can play this game no matter where you are.

A few things to keep in mind:

Keep your feeding hand steady. Place treats into it rather than lifting your hand to reach for each one. This small detail helps your dog stay focused between treats instead of breaking their attention to follow your hand movement.

If your dog struggles to stay focused for three treats, start with one treat and release, then two and release, and build from there. There's no rush. The goal is that they feel successful, not pressured.

Start this game in an easy environment – somewhere with minimal distractions and enough space for your dog to chase the release treat comfortably. As the game becomes natural to them, you can gradually take it into busier, more challenging places.

Some dogs will find this game easier to start while their handler sits down. If needed, go down to your dog's level until they feel comfortable with the game and can start playing it with real motion.

Sometimes, instead of tossing a treat on the floor with your release marker, simply turn and walk away. This teaches your dog that the release signal means genuine disengagement – not just a cue that a treat is coming. Varying between the two keeps the meaning of the marker clear and honest.



The True Meaning of the Release

Most people focus on getting their dog to stay. But the real skill is in the release.

A clear release marker tells your dog: the exercise is over, you are free. Without it, your dog is left guessing – am I still working? Can I move? What happens if I shift?

That uncertainty creates stress. And stress kills engagement.

When your dog trusts that every exercise has a clear ending, they can relax into the work. They know it will not last forever. They know freedom is coming.

Rewards build value.

Releases build commitment.



Rewarding your dog build value.

Releasing them build commitment.

– Game 2: Reinforce & Release

03

GAME 03

Luring

Teaching your dog to follow hand movements with confidence,
trust, and understanding.

Luring

Why do we play this game?

Luring teaches a dog to follow the handler's hand with confidence and trust. It is one of the most fundamental skills in training, and also one of the most misunderstood. Many dog owners treat luring as a shortcut: moving food in front of their dog's nose in the shape of a trick. But real luring is about communication. It teaches the dog that the hand is a guide, not a bribe.

Done well, luring builds a dog who moves willingly, trusts the handler's hand movements, and understands that following that guidance always leads somewhere good. It is simple, clear, and confidence-building, making it an excellent tool for beginner dogs and handlers alike, and far more than just a way to teach tricks. At its core, it's a genuine form of conversation between dog and handler.

The key is patience: move slowly, let the dog succeed, and always mark the moment they follow, so they know exactly what earned the reward.

Beyond teaching a dog to read hand motion, proper luring helps a dog understand the difference between a Keep Going marker and a Confirmation marker. It builds confidence and allows the dog to discover new movements and positions with clarity. Most importantly, it builds trust, because the dog must believe both in the handler and in themselves while they follow.

Luring — How to Play

How to play

Place a treat between two fingers and your thumb so it is easy for your dog to notice and reach. When your dog makes their first attempt to get it, use your Static Confirmation marker and remove your thumb so they can access the treat.

Repeat a few times until your dog gains confidence in approaching your hand. Then, when they do, start using your Keep Going marker before the confirmation so that they understand they are doing well and that the treat will come soon.

Slowly start moving your hand slightly so they need to follow it and maintain contact with it while in motion, without having full access to the treat. After a small movement, use your Confirmation marker and release the treat.

Keep building duration in both hands until you can increase the difficulty by adding more steps, changing the tempo, and trying different directions and shapes.

A few things to keep in mind

It is not enough for your dog to know how to follow each hand separately. They also need to learn how to transition between hands smoothly, without getting stuck on one side. Train that transition on its own before building a full luring flow.

If your dog struggles to follow the lure, slow down and go back a few steps. Make the movement slower, shorter, and easier to follow. Create success before adding difficulty.

Luring is not a race. Every dog learns at their own pace, and our job is to make it as clear as possible from the very first moment.

Don't be in a hurry to remove the treats or the lure. It's better to take the time to make it clear rather than having to revisit the exercise because you rushed your dog.

04

GAME 04

Eye Contact & Self Control

Teaching your dog to resist temptation and offer eye contact as
a way of saying: I am with you.

Eye Contact & Self Control

Why do we play this game?

The Eye Contact & Self Control game is all about accuracy, coordination, and timing. This behavior is one of the hardest things we ask of a dog, even though it feels completely natural to us, but in this game, we teach it step by step, with as little pressure as possible.

This exercise teaches self control and visual communication at the same time. The dog learns to resist the treat in the handler's hand and wait for a decision, rather than trying to grab the reward. But the real goal goes further than that: the dog should not just give up on the treat, but look at the handler instead, choosing eye contact over food as the way to make the reward happen.

Self control is not about suppression. It is about teaching the dog that patience pays off, that waiting is not punishment, but a strategy that leads to reward. Eye contact becomes the bridge between dog and handler: when a dog looks at the handler voluntarily, they are saying, I am with you. I am ready. Tell me what is next.

What makes this game especially meaningful is the visual language it builds. The open hand and the closed hand become signals the dog learns to read. When the hand closes, the dog knows they made a mistake and need to change their behavior. When the hand opens, it's a sign they are on the right track, but they still need to wait for verbal confirmation before taking the treat. This connects directly to the luring language already established, adding a new layer of communication between dog and handler.

Together, these skills create a dog who can think clearly in the presence of temptation, and who chooses connection over impulse.

Eye Contact & Self Control

How to play

This exercise has two distinct parts. Start with self control, and only move to eye contact once your dog is comfortable with the first part.

Part 1: Self Control

Hold a treat in your closed fist and place it close to your dog's nose. Wait. No matter what they do, pawing, nudging, whining, keep your hand closed and don't move it. The moment they stop trying to get the treat, mark and reward.

Repeat until your dog starts to understand that backing off is what makes the reward happen. Then slowly open your hand with the treat visible. Your dog should now ignore it. If they move toward it or try to take it, close your hand again. Reopen only once they have backed off and settled.

Make sure to practice with both hands so your dog understands the behavior is not tied to one side.

Part 2: Eye Contact

Once your dog is comfortable with self control around an open hand, hold both hands closed in front of them and slowly open them apart. Reward your dog for keeping their eyes on your face rather than on the treats. When your dog understands this, you can start adding a verbal cue before opening your hands.

From there, begin creating small distractions by moving your hands while your dog looks at you. If they look away, either start the sequence again or simply stop moving and wait for them to look back before continuing.

Keep gradually adding more distractions, and make sure to practice with empty hands too. Opening your hands with nothing in them should eventually become an eye contact cue on its own.

Eye Contact & Self Control

A few things to keep in mind

Teaching a dog to look us in the eyes is sometimes harder than we expect. To understand why, we first need to remember that in dog language, direct eye contact can be a way to challenge or even threaten another dog. Because of this, eye contact may not come naturally to every dog, and patience is essential.

Every dog has a different frustration threshold, so to prevent pressure building up before your dog knows how to handle it, it's both allowed and recommended to reinforce steps along the way. For example, if your dog looks away from your fist, even just for a moment, you can mark and reward that. It tells them they're heading in the right direction. Just be careful not to over-reinforce that specific step, since the goal is self control, not avoidance.

When rewarding, always deliver the treat from the opposite hand to the one your dog last looked at. If your dog looked at your right hand before giving up on the treat or looking at you, reward from your left, and vice versa. This keeps the exercise clean and prevents your dog from learning to simply look away from the hand that has the treat.

Practice this exercise in different environments and with your dog in different positions, sitting, standing, lying down, and more. Once your dog understands the behavior, start changing your own position as well. This helps your dog learn to offer eye contact regardless of what you are doing or how you are positioned.

If your dog is especially sensitive or fearful, it may take them longer to offer eye contact freely. In these cases, reward even very small steps toward it.

Don't wait for perfection. Confidence is built one small step at a time.



Connection Over Compliance

Eye contact is not obedience. It is communication.

When your dog looks at you, they are not submitting. They are connecting. They are asking: what now? They are saying: I trust you.

This is the foundation of everything we build in training. A dog who checks in with you voluntarily is a dog who wants to be part of the team.

Self-control and eye contact together create a dog who can navigate the world calmly. Not because they are suppressing their instincts, but because they have learned that patience and connection always lead somewhere good.

05

GAME 05

Follow Up

Your dog learns to maintain focus and engagement when the
treat isn't there.

Follow Up

Why do we play this game?

Follow Up is a direct progression of Reinforce & Release. Same position, same commitment, but now the dog has to think, move, and stay with the handler at the same time, even when the treat is no longer there.

In Reinforce & Release, the dog learned to hold focus between treats while moving toward the handler. Now the question becomes whether that same focus can hold out of trust, even when a treat is not coming.

This game prepares the dog for the front position, one of the most used positions throughout training, while building mental endurance, patience, and the ability to stay focused while waiting for confirmation. Instead of rewarding the dog at every step, the handler now praises them for following in motion, using the Keep Going marker to keep them engaged without relying on treats.

The dog learns to stay connected to the handler not because of a lure in hand, but because the pattern of reinforcement makes staying close worthwhile. This is also what makes the game valuable beyond the front position itself: it builds concentration, the ability to handle distractions, and duration of focus during movement, skills that carry into everything built from here.

Follow Up

How to play

Start by playing a few repetitions of Reinforce & Release to warm your dog up and get them into the game. Then, instead of giving an immediate reward, use your Keep Going marker to keep your dog engaged as you take one more step backwards. After that extra step, stop and use multiple Static Confirmations with a treat in every repetition, then release your dog.

When your dog comes back from the release, play the normal Reinforce & Release version a few more times before challenging them again with Follow Up. During the Follow Up, try to hold your hands behind your back or at your sides so your dog has to think about the position in front of you, rather than following your hands.

Slowly start increasing the duration of each repetition. Use your Keep Going marker as you walk backwards, praising your dog for staying in front of you and maintaining focus while in motion. Reward only when you give the Static Confirmation marker. Keep building the game and combine it naturally with Reinforce & Release, moving between the two so your dog learns to stay engaged through both stillness and movement.

A few things to keep in mind

This game is one of the most important reads you have as a handler. Think of it this way: if your dog can follow for 10 seconds, they can hold a sequence for 5. If they can do it for 2 minutes, they are ready to dance for one. Use this game to understand where your dog actually is, not where you hope they are.

Many people skip this game or teach the front position through luring instead and the dog becomes dependent on the hands rather than truly understanding the position.

Here, your dog learns to hold the position on their own, which means you can eventually move your hands freely without losing their focus. That is what makes it stick.

That's why it's important to keep your hands behind your back or at your sides as much as possible during the game and only start to move them as distractions at first.

Combine this game regularly with Reinforce & Release. Since Follow Up asks more of your dog, longer duration and no treats between steps, returning to Reinforce & Release between repetitions helps prevent frustration and keeps the difficulty from feeling like it only ever goes up. Moving between the two keeps your dog engaged, and motivated.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Focus Without the Treat

The real milestone in Follow Up isn't reaching the front position. It's the dog choosing to stay engaged once the treat disappears.

That's your dog saying, "I trust you."

Make sure to notice and reward it.

CHALLENGE

5 Days – 5 Games

it's Game Time!



5 Days – 5 Games

Your mission is straightforward:

5 different games in 5 different environments over 5 days.

Each day, you will pick one environment and play the engagement games you've learned in previous lessons.

This will help your dog check in with you, respond quickly, and slowly learn to choose you, even with distractions.

Make a habit out of writing down notes from each training write down moments of Success: What did your dog do well today and what did you do well?

Writing down the good things, will help you keep the motivation on the harder days.

Describe the Difficulty: What was the environment like, or how long was the training? If you want to make sure you can help your dog in a moment of need – you first need to know how the world affects them.

One thing you'll do differently so tomorrow can be better: Using higher value of treats, choosing an easier environment or a different time during the day, whatever it takes to make the next training more fun.

Record and share your training!

When we're training a dog we have to stay in the moment. That's why recording our training is an incredible way to learn.

When we watch a recording we can notice things we didn't realize during the training session; small body gestures we do without an intention, wrong timing for markers, and even moments we could have rewarded and missed out.

You can use the recordings to learn and improve before the next time you'll take your dog out for a training, but you can also use it in the future, to watch after a few weeks, a few months or a few days to see how far you've come!

Thank You

You have completed Module 2: Feeding Drive.
Remember, every treat is an opportunity to connect.



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